

Strategic Vision & OpenAIRE's Role in Empowering the CoARA Community

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1.Introduction and Background

OpenAIRE AMKE is a non-profit organisation dedicated to advancing Open Science by operating an Open Scholarly Communication e-Infrastructure supporting the accessibility, transparency, dissemination and reuse of research. Its mission is carried out through the collective efforts of its 52 members, including universities, research institutions, libraries, and national funding agencies from across 39 countries in Europe. These members, particularly the National Open Access Desks (NOADs), work together to empower researchers, institutions, and policymakers with the knowledge, infrastructure, and services needed to adopt and promote Open Science practices.

The [OpenAIRE Strategy 2023-2025](#) prioritises advancing **Responsible Research Assessment (RRA)** in alignment with Open Science principles through key actions:

- **Fostering an Inclusive Open Infrastructure for Scholarly Communication:** OpenAIRE develops an infrastructure that supports RRA ensuring it is inclusive, diverse, and reproducible. Beyond technical infrastructure, OpenAIRE actively fosters a human infrastructure by creating a collaborative learning environment among its members.
- **Promoting Open Science in Research Assessment Criteria:** OpenAIRE emphasises the value of Open Science as a cornerstone of research assessment. By integrating Open Science principles into evaluation frameworks, OpenAIRE supports greater transparency, equity, and collaboration across research ecosystems.
- **Developing an Innovative Researcher Profile Service:** OpenAIRE is designing a new Researcher Profile Service to balance quantitative and qualitative research assessment, combining narrative evaluations, with data-driven insights and responsible metrics to promote diversity, inclusivity, and openness, providing a holistic and equitable assessment framework that aligns with the evolving needs of researchers and institutions.

Recognising the critical role of RRA in fostering Open Science, OpenAIRE signed the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment \(ARRA\)](#) in 2022. This reflects its commitment to advancing frameworks that value diverse research outputs, prioritise transparency, and align evaluation practices with the principles of openness and collaboration. OpenAIRE advocates that research assessment should encourage quality, inclusivity, and societal impact, moving beyond traditional metrics to support meaningful contributions to knowledge.

2. OpenAIRE Actions to Advance CoARA Commitments (2024–2028)

OpenAIRE fully embraces the principles outlined in the ARRA and is actively implementing its ten core commitments. As a signatory of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) and an engaged member of its community, OpenAIRE is dedicated to promoting Open Science and fostering RRA practices across Europe and globally. These efforts are grounded in OpenAIRE's three foundational pillars: its robust **network** of partners and stakeholders, innovative and interoperable **services**, and comprehensive **training** initiatives. The following document will highlight the specific action points and progress made along these pillars, showcasing how OpenAIRE's integrated approach aligns with and supports the objectives of the ARRA commitments.

COMMITMENT 1: RECOGNISE THE DIVERSITY OF CONTRIBUTIONS TO, AND CAREERS IN, RESEARCH IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE NEEDS AND NATURE OF THE RESEARCH

Current Status: OpenAIRE is dedicated to inclusive research assessment by showcasing diverse research outputs and embedding Open Science principles.

- Through its **network**, OpenAIRE provides updated policy checklists to its members, ensuring the adoption of RRA practices and recognizing diverse contributions.
- With its **services**, including the OpenAIRE Graph, MONITOR, and CONNECT, OpenAIRE captures and integrates diverse research outputs into institutional evaluation workflows, ensuring their inclusion by design.
- OpenAIRE's **training** initiatives equip institutions with the tools and knowledge to build interoperable systems that align RRA with Open Science principles.

Planned Actions

1. Update and enrich the existing OpenAIRE Guidelines to better incorporate datasets, software, and non-traditional outputs, ensuring their seamless integration into open scholarly infrastructures and evaluation frameworks.
2. Launch the new OpenAIRE Research Profile Service to pilot innovative approaches covering diverse research outputs.
3. Provide targeted training to support institutions and research communities in integrating local infrastructures with the OpenAIRE Graph, enabling seamless monitoring of research activities, diverse outputs, and indicators.

COMMITMENT 2: BASE RESEARCH ASSESSMENT PRIMARILY ON QUALITATIVE EVALUATION FOR WHICH PEER REVIEW IS CENTRAL, SUPPORTED BY RESPONSIBLE USE OF QUANTITATIVE INDICATORS

Current Status: OpenAIRE promotes RRA, prioritises peer-reviewed qualitative evaluation supported by evidence-based indicators.

- OpenAIRE's services, with the OpenAIRE Graph in the centre, provide a rich metadata infrastructure to support evidence-based peer review processes. These services enable researchers and institutions to track diverse research outputs, ensuring that evaluations are grounded in qualitative evidence.
- OpenAIRE co-leads the CoARA Working Group Towards Open infrastructures for Responsible Research Assessment (OI₄RRA) and contributes to Responsible Metrics and Indicators (RMI) Working Group, to shape policies that prioritise qualitative research assessment and align with Open Science principles.

Planned Actions

1. Enhancing RRA through the launch of the OpenAIRE Researcher Profile Service, to prioritise qualitative evaluation while responsibly incorporating evidence based indicators.
2. Collaborate with member institutions to pilot narrative-driven evaluation models using Open Infrastructures like the OpenAIRE Graph, ensuring quantitative indicators are meaningful, responsible, context-specific and aligned with Open Science principles, ensuring they remain secondary to qualitative evaluation.
3. Raise awareness and conducting training programs for research managers and evaluators in adopting qualitative assessment practices, guiding institutions and communities in integrating the OpenAIRE Researcher Profile Service into workflows to support qualitative evaluation.

COMMITMENT 3: ABANDON INAPPROPRIATE USES IN RESEARCH ASSESSMENT OF JOURNAL- AND PUBLICATION-BASED METRICS, IN PARTICULAR INAPPROPRIATE USES OF JOURNAL IMPACT FACTOR (JIF) AND H-INDEX

Current Status: OpenAIRE is fully aligned with COARA's commitment to abandoning inappropriate journal-based metrics in research assessment.

- OpenAIRE services aggregate a wide array of data points, presenting them neutrally and transparently, ensuring institutions and stakeholders can derive insights responsibly without reliance on journal-based proxies.

Planned Actions

1. Collaborate with member institutions and the broader community to promote awareness of the limitations of journal-based metrics, offering guidance on alternative and responsible assessment practices
2. Develop and roll out the Researcher Profile Service and enhance the OpenAIRE MONITOR Service to showcase practical applications of diverse indicators for researchers, institutions, and funders. Collaborate with experts and pilot users to prevent the misuse of indicators across various contexts.

COMMITMENT 4: AVOID THE USE OF RANKINGS OF RESEARCH ORGANISATIONS IN RESEARCH ASSESSMENT

Current efforts: OpenAIRE is committed to avoiding the use of rankings in research assessment, promoting transparency and fairness, in how research outcomes are monitored and presented.

- OpenAIRE collects and curates information about research outcomes, assigning them to institutions through affiliations. This data is presented neutrally and non-comparatively to ensure impartiality and support holistic evaluation.
- OpenAIRE supports and empowers its members to drive meaningful institutional change by providing regular updates and consultations, keeping them informed developments in research monitoring landscape and aligned with best practices.

Planned Actions

1. Continue to prioritise the neutral presentation of research outcomes, staying away from any form of rankings, while advancing monitoring tools to provide institutions with transparent and actionable insights without fostering competition.
2. Increase support for member institutions in fostering cultural change, as well as for adopting these practices.

COMMITMENT 5: COMMIT RESOURCES TO REFORMING RESEARCH ASSESSMENT AS IS NEEDED TO ACHIEVE THE ORGANISATIONAL CHANGES COMMITTED TO

Current efforts: OpenAIRE commits resources to advancing the reform of research assessment, investing in infrastructure, expertise, and human capital to drive the organisational changes necessary for meaningful progress.

- Commits resources to co-chair and coordinate the CoARA OI4RRA Working Group, advocating for open, trustworthy, and responsible infrastructures that advance the reform of research assessment.
- Commits resources to advancing the reform of research assessment by providing dedicated tools and services to support relevant stakeholders in performing institutional change.

Planned Actions:

1. Prioritise services like the OpenAIRE Researcher Profile to capture diverse research outputs, particularly for communities like Computer Science, AI, and SSH.
2. Advocate for funding policies that support open, community-driven infrastructures, ensuring sustainability and systemic reform aligned with RRA and Open Science principles.
3. Develop training programmes for policymakers and research executives, including train-the-trainer activities and practical guides, to help institutions adopt and implement RRA practices.

COMMITMENT 6: REVIEW AND DEVELOP RESEARCH ASSESSMENT CRITERIA, TOOLS AND PROCESSES

Current efforts: OpenAIRE actively supports institutions in customizing and scaling their research assessment processes through the following:

- Contributing to global and regional policy discussions, co-leading and coordinating the CoARA OI4RRA Working Group, participating in the CoARA RMI Working Group, and driving innovation through participation in the GraspOS Horizon Europe project and UNESCO's Open Science Monitoring.
- Advancing its infrastructure to support RRA reform, with services that promote FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable) principles, enriching metadata, and enable mechanisms for responsible metrics development.

Planned Actions:

1. Develop comprehensive and inclusive research assessment criteria by the end of 2025 through the GraspOS Horizon Europe Project, incorporating diversified metrics to support the successful adoption of assessment reforms.
2. Continue leadership in the CoARA OI4RRA Working Group to develop guidelines, best practices and recommendations for operating open infrastructures fit for RRA.

COMMITMENT 7: RAISE AWARENESS OF RESEARCH ASSESSMENT REFORM AND PROVIDE TRANSPARENT COMMUNICATION, GUIDANCE, AND TRAINING ON ASSESSMENT CRITERIA AND PROCESSES AS WELL AS THEIR USE

Current Efforts: Aligned with the [OpenAIRE Strategy 2023–2025](#), OpenAIRE advocates for the importance of Open Infrastructures and Open Science as foundational elements of research assessment reform.

- OpenAIRE collaborates with members and stakeholders to enhance fairness, inclusivity and transparency in evaluation practices, by raising awareness, providing policy guidance and supporting the adoption of equitable criteria.
- OpenAIRE delivers targeted training and guidance to raise awareness of RRA through the GraspOS Horizon Europe project.

Planned Actions:

1. Broaden training efforts to include policymakers and research managers, equipping decision-makers with the tools to implement RRA practices, supported by multilingual materials to effectively reach diverse regions.
2. Provide organizations with practical tools and resources, including handbooks, policy checklists and innovative indicators, to facilitate alignment with RRA standards.
3. Conduct webinars through the GraspOS Horizon Europe project and the OI4RRA Working Group to showcase developments and highlight the critical role of openness in research evaluation systems, promoting RRA practices through practical insights and cross regional dialogue.

COMMITMENT 8: EXCHANGE PRACTICES AND EXPERIENCES TO ENABLE MUTUAL LEARNING WITHIN AND BEYOND THE COALITION

Current Status: OpenAIRE facilitates practice exchange and collaboration through its network of members, regular Community Calls, training sessions, and global events,

including the biennial [Open Science FAIR](#), a key platform for advancing discussions on Open Science and RRA.

- OpenAIRE fosters community building through its leadership in the OL4RRA Working Group and participation in the GraspOS Horizon Europe project, creating collaborative environments that promote the exchange of best practices and success stories.
- OpenAIRE enables mutual learning opportunities by engaging its members through Community Calls, training sessions, and events, enabling stakeholders to stay informed and adopt emerging best practices.

Planned Actions:

1. Design and implement actionable scenarios to support RRA adoption by analyzing the underlying infrastructure, costs and skills needed for the process.
2. Strengthen community engagement through consultations, collaborative meetings, and workshops to promote Open Infrastructures.
3. Facilitate knowledge exchange via workshops, training sessions, and digital platforms to share tools, methodologies, and case studies. Collaborate and participate in global events (e.g. [OSFAIR2025](#)) to integrate international best practices into scalable and effective RRA strategies.

COMMITMENT 9: COMMUNICATE PROGRESS MADE ON ADHERENCE TO THE PRINCIPLES AND IMPLEMENTATION OF THE COMMITMENTS

Current Status: OpenAIRE ensures transparency and accountability by reporting progress on the CoARA Commitments. OpenAIRE's work is reflected in various activities:

- Communication of progress and adherence to the CoARA Principles is embedded in outreach initiatives, including blog articles, interviews, consultation and project updates.
- OpenAIRE participates in and organises academic, policy, and training events to communicate progress, such as CoARA events, global conferences and other relevant opportunities.

Planned Actions:

1. Increase outreach efforts by participating in key events like the Barcelona Declaration Working Groups, OSMI Working Groups and international conferences to promote CoARA activities, particularly focusing on the work of the OL4RRA Working Group.

2. Lead efforts to shape policies that align with CoARA commitments, ensuring inclusivity and support for open research infrastructure principles.
3. As the OpenAIRE Strategy undergoes revision, OpenAIRE will embed CoARA commitments into its evolving strategy.

COMMITMENT 10: EVALUATE PRACTICES, CRITERIA AND TOOLS BASED ON SOLID EVIDENCE AND THE STATE-OF-THE-ART IN RESEARCH ON RESEARCH, AND MAKE DATA OPENLY AVAILABLE FOR EVIDENCE GATHERING AND RESEARCH

Current Status: OpenAIRE has been committed to continuously evaluating research practices, criteria, and tools to ensure they are grounded in solid evidence and reflect the latest advancements in research methodologies.

- OpenAIRE champions evidence-based practices through its engagement in projects such as GraspOS, which collects, analyses, and shares data to advance RRA.
- OpenAIRE services, including OpenAIRE Graph, provide open and FAIR data to promote transparency and evidence-based decision-making.
- OpenAIRE advances evidence-based practices through its engagement in projects such as GraspOS Horizon Europe project, participation in UNESCO's Open Science Monitoring and the CoARA Working Group on RMI, ensuring evaluation criteria and tools align with global best practices and Open Science principles.

Planned Actions:

1. Adopt the OI4RRA Working Group outputs by advancing FAIR compliance and interoperability in services like the OpenAIRE Graph.
2. Define and implement indicators to assess Open Science impact and RRA policies.
3. Continue developing guidelines and recommendations for indicators measuring Open Science impact, aligning evaluation practices with societal and economic goals.
4. Contribute to evidence collection and analysis through Collaborative Research on Research (RoR) to ensure findings are widely disseminated and accessible, enabling global benchmarking and continuous improvement.

3. Empowering CoARA Commitments via Services and Horizon Europe Projects

SERVICE/ NETWORK	ROLE IN SUPPORTING COARA COMMITMENTS	COMMIT- MENTS	RELEVANT PROJECTS
National Open Access Desks (NOADs)	Facilitates global collaboration on Open Science policies and standards.	7, 8	UNESCO Collaborations, Global Open Science Movement
OpenAIRE Graph	Collects, Deduplicates and enrich research metadata records from registered data sources and service /registry providers collaborators to deliver an Open Infrastructure which serves as a database to perform research assessment.	1, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10	EOSC, SciLake, GraspOS, EVERSE, OSTrails
OpenAIRE CONNECT	Provides collaborative spaces for RPOs to develop thematic portals that support qualitative evaluation and peer-reviewed research.	1, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10	EOSC, GraspOS, SciLake
OpenAIRE MONITOR	Tracks compliance with Open Science and CoARA-aligned practices, promoting transparency and recognition of diverse contributions.	5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10 (indirectly it also addresses 1, 2, 3, 4)	GraspOS, Irish Monitor, EOSC Open Science Observatory
ARGOS	Simplifies and automates the creation of research management plans that align with RDM policies.	5, 6, 7, 10	OSTrails, TIER-2, FAIR principles related-projects
Metadata Validator	Ensures high-quality metadata, supporting visibility and documentation of diverse research outputs.	1, 2, 6, 9, 10	Thematic Extensions Projects, University Alliances

Researcher Profile	Enables researchers to showcase diverse contributions, promoting comprehensive career assessments.	1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10	GraspOS, PathOS
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3.1. Timeline and Key Milestones



PathOS: PathOS is a Horizon Europe project aiming to collect concrete evidence of Open Science effects, study the pathways of Open Science practices, from input to output, outcome and impact, including the consideration of enabling factors and key barriers.

SciLake: SciLake is a Horizon Europe project that aims to introduce and establish the concept of the scientific lake, a research ecosystem where scientific knowledge is contextualised, connected, interoperable, and accessible overcoming challenges related to the heterogeneity and large interconnectivity of the underlying data.

GraspOS: GraspOS is a Horizon Europe project with the aim is to investigate responsible research assessment approaches and interventions that take into consideration Open Science practices and to build a federated infrastructure that will act as an open data space offering data, indicators, tools, services and guidance to support and enable policy reform for research assessment.